

ENGLISH FOR WORK / SEPTEMBER 2026

Cooks and Kitchen Staff English



Teacher's guide

Teach practical workplace communication with specific cases, clear language targets, and a repeatable feedback process.

PRACTICE THAT TRANSFERS TO WORK

Read a realistic case. Study complete conversations. Find the right language, speak, get feedback, and try again.

Eight lessons | Intermediate to advanced | Independent or classroom study

For Line cooks, prep cooks, kitchen assistants, and dish-team colleagues.

All situations, quantities, recipes, times, and product details are fictional English practice, not culinary certification or food-safety instruction. This course does not teach cooking temperatures, chemical use, equipment repair, or allergen-control procedures. Follow workplace training and the responsible kitchen lead's decisions. It concerns kitchen communication rather than hospitality management.

All scenarios, figures, and model responses are fictional teaching material. Use invented details in practice.

[Open this course on English Ladder](#)

Your course at a glance

Use the lesson numbers to match this document with the website and the other guides.

01 Clarifying a prep list

Clarify quantities before interpreting a kitchen shorthand.

02 Reporting deliveries and stock discrepancies

Distinguish a physical count from an expected quantity.

03 Reading tickets and modifications

Read back ticket identity, revised quantity, and the exact change.

04 Coordinating the pass

Separate individual dish progress from readiness of the full order.

05 Communicating a shortage and an alternative

Explain a shortage and obtain the missing choice.

06 Checking dietary modifications

Challenge an overbroad conclusion using the stated dietary concern.

07 Reporting equipment and dish-station needs

Request a named response to an observed equipment problem.

08 Closing and handing over unfinished work

Transfer closing work without making incomplete checks disappear.

Choose your pace

Quick practice: spend 15 minutes reading one conversation and rehearsing one scenario. Full lesson: allow 45-60 minutes for language work, three conversations, two speaking scenarios, and feedback.

Level support

B1 learners can use the frames and a partner. B2 learners can try a response before reading the model. C1 learners can add the harder follow-up and reduce preparation time. These are teaching suggestions, not certified CEFR level ratings.

After practicing: open the AI prompt workshop to choose a vocabulary, grammar, role-play, or new-dialogue activity.

A 60-minute lesson that works

Prepare the case and the learner pages. Keep the model response hidden until learners have attempted their own. Choose two field terms that are important to understanding the case.

0-5 minutes | Activate experience

Ask learners to name a comparable situation without sharing confidential details. Introduce the communication goal.

5-12 minutes | Read and sort facts

Read the case. Learners identify confirmed facts, unknowns, the audience, and the immediate communication need.

12-22 minutes | Notice and practice language

Explain the workshop pattern. Work through the vocabulary and editing example, then discuss both language checks and the reasons behind the choices.

22-35 minutes | 05 • Conversations

Read one ten-turn conversation aloud, notice a useful expression, then compare the other two. Identify each speaker's purpose and how the exchange ends.

35-47 minutes | 06 • Say it

Rehearse both speaking scenarios from the workbook. Give two minutes of preparation, switch roles, and use the success checks. Add the complication only after a successful first round.

47-55 minutes | Compare and revise

Reveal the model. Discuss alternative acceptable wording. Give one meaning correction and one language correction, then repeat.

55-60 minutes | Retrieve and transfer

Close the materials. Learners recall two expressions and identify one communication habit to use in another situation.

Adapt the session

For 45 minutes, study one complete conversation and rehearse one scenario; assign the others for oral follow-up. For 90 minutes, rehearse all three conversations and give both scenarios a second round. More time should produce more meaningful practice, not longer explanations.

LESSON 01 / FACILITATOR NOTES

Clarifying a prep list

Clarify quantities before interpreting a kitchen shorthand.

CASE

The prep list says 'soup: 24' without a unit. Yesterday's sheet used portions; the storeroom label uses containers. The lead intended 24 portions from the current recipe, not 24 containers. No batch has started.

Teach this move

Numbers need units. A recipe's yield and a container count describe different things; familiarity with yesterday's sheet isn't confirmation for today.

Vocabulary to check: mise en place, prep list, yield, batch.

Model response

The soup line says twenty-four, but it doesn't specify portions or containers. Before I start a batch, could you confirm the unit and the recipe version? Yesterday's sheet used portions, while the storage label counts containers. I'll repeat the required yield once we know which quantity today's prep list means.

Listen for, then coach

Ask learners to point to the case fact behind each important statement. Accept different wording when it preserves meaning, fits the listener, and does not invent an outcome. The question attaches a unit and recipe to the number.

Second-round challenge

The cook finds a second sheet dated Friday. Identify which sheet governs today's task.

Language-check answers

1. C - portions Correct. Portions count the individual servings the lead specified.
2. C - which recipe Correct. The noun phrase is the subject of 'applies'.

05 • Conversations

1. Twenty-four what? - The ambiguous soup prep line in the case.
2. A total, not an addition - A kitchen assistant clarifies a revised list during preparation.
3. Prep ready for whom? - A cook checks what a colleague means by 'ready'.

Use the complete ten-turn scripts in the learner workbook and conversation lab. Read with roles, identify the decision or open question, then replay without reading.

06 · Say it: second scenario | A handwritten abbreviation

A prep note reads '6 c.' The recipe uses cups, but the delivery list uses cases. The lead intended six cups for a practice recipe discussion; no preparation has begun.

Role A: Cook: ask what the abbreviation means.

Role B: Lead: expand it to cups and identify the recipe, not a delivery order.

Possible opening: Could you spell out the unit beside the six?

Success checks

- Identify the current document.
- Obtain the full unit.
- Repeat the quantity without using the ambiguous abbreviation.

Add a complication: A colleague says the same abbreviation meant cases yesterday.

LESSON 02 / FACILITATOR NOTES

Reporting deliveries and stock discrepancies

Distinguish a physical count from an expected quantity.

CASE

The delivery note lists six cases of tomatoes; four are physically present. The driver says two may be on another trolley but has not checked. The receiving lead must resolve the record. Report the observed count without accusing the supplier or recording six as received.

Teach this move

Use 'lists' for the document and 'counted' for the observation. A possible explanation is not a verified delivery.

Vocabulary to check: delivery note, short delivery, traceability, lot code.

Model response

I can count four tomato cases here, while the delivery note lists six. Two may be on the other trolley, but that hasn't been checked. Please keep the received quantity unconfirmed until the receiving lead reconciles the count. I'll show them the four cases and the delivery note together.

Listen for, then coach

Ask learners to point to the case fact behind each important statement. Accept different wording when it preserves meaning, fits the listener, and does not invent an outcome. This reports the discrepancy without inventing a cause.

Second-round challenge

The driver finds one more case. Update the observed count to five without declaring the delivery complete.

Language-check answers

1. D - unconfirmed Correct. The driver offers a possibility, not a verified location.
2. D - counted Correct. This reports an observation.

05 • Conversations

1. Six on paper, four on the floor - The tomato delivery count in the case.

2. A label cannot be read - A kitchen assistant reports an unreadable product identifier.
3. Stock on hand versus available - A cook checks whether counted portions are already allocated.

Use the complete ten-turn scripts in the learner workbook and conversation lab. Read with roles, identify the decision or open question, then replay without reading.

06 · Say it: second scenario | One box is a different product

A delivery note lists five cases of plain rolls. There are four plain-roll cases and one seeded-roll case. No substitution was agreed.

Role A: Cook: state counts and product names.

Role B: Receiving lead: review the mismatch with the supplier before accepting a substitution.

Possible opening: The fifth case has a different product description.

Success checks

- Count by product, not just container.
- Avoid declaring the substitute equivalent.
- Identify the unresolved substitution decision.

Add a complication: A colleague calls it 'five bread cases' and overlooks the product difference.

LESSON 03 / FACILITATOR NOTES

Reading tickets and modifications

Read back ticket identity, revised quantity, and the exact change.

CASE

Ticket 41 originally has two tarts. A new slip says 'three tarts, revised 41.' The expediter confirms this replaces the old quantity, so the total is three, not five. One tart has salad instead of potatoes. Confirm quantity and substitution.

Teach this move

A revised ticket may replace an earlier instruction. 'Instead of' signals replacement; 'as well as' signals addition.

Vocabulary to check: ticket, all day, on the fly, substitution.

Model response

Does the revised ticket replace the two-tart quantity on ticket forty-one, or add three more? If it replaces it, I have three tarts total, with salad instead of potatoes on one. Please confirm that modification applies to only one tart so I don't change all three plates.

Listen for, then coach

Ask learners to point to the case fact behind each important statement. Accept different wording when it preserves meaning, fits the listener, and does not invent an outcome. The distinction prevents duplicate production.

Second-round challenge

Someone calls 'three more' after the correction. Repair the quantity before work continues.

Language-check answers

1. B - total Correct. Three is the complete revised quantity.
2. D - instead of Correct. 'Instead of' marks replacement of the potatoes.

05 • Conversations

1. Three total, not five - Revised ticket 41 from the case.
2. What does all day include? - A cook checks the scope of an order total.
3. Urgent is not specific - A cook clarifies an urgent verbal request.

Use the complete ten-turn scripts in the learner workbook and conversation lab. Read with roles, identify the decision or open question, then replay without reading.

06 · Say it: second scenario | A canceled side remains on a screen

Ticket 72 originally includes two extra salads. The expediter confirms one extra salad is canceled; the mains are unchanged.

Role A: Cook: clarify the remaining quantity.

Role B: Expediter: confirm one extra salad remains and both mains still stand.

Possible opening: Does this cancellation remove one salad or the whole ticket?

Success checks

- Keep both mains.
- State one extra salad remains.
- Repeat the ticket number when correcting the colleague.

Add a complication: A colleague heard only the word 'cancel'.

LESSON 04 / FACILITATOR NOTES

Coordinating the pass

Separate individual dish progress from readiness of the full order.

CASE

Ticket 28 has four mains. Two are plated; two are still at the cook's station. The cook estimates four more minutes for the remaining pair. The expeditor asks whether the whole table is ready. Report partial progress and the current estimate.

Teach this move

'Two are plated' doesn't mean 'four are ready.' Name the remaining items and the reference point for an estimate.

Vocabulary to check: pass, expeditor, pickup, plating.

Model response

Ticket twenty-eight is not complete yet. Two mains are plated, and the other two are still at my station. My current estimate for that pair is four more minutes. Please don't call the full pickup yet. I'll update you when the remaining dishes are ready for your check at the pass.

Listen for, then coach

Ask learners to point to the case fact behind each important statement. Accept different wording when it preserves meaning, fits the listener, and does not invent an outcome. The update shows what prevents a full pickup.

Second-round challenge

The runner points to the two plated dishes and assumes the whole ticket can leave.

Language-check answers

1. C - still pending Correct. This identifies incomplete work.
2. D - approximate Correct. The adjective modifies 'wait'.

05 • Conversations

1. Half a ticket is not a pickup - Ticket 28 from the case.
2. A garnish mismatch at the pass - An expeditor questions a visible difference between a dish and its ticket.
3. The runner needs the whole location - A cook repairs a vague pickup announcement.

Use the complete ten-turn scripts in the learner workbook and conversation lab. Read with roles, identify the decision or open question, then replay without reading.

06 · Say it: second scenario | A takeaway order at the dining pass

Three containers for takeaway ticket 90 are ready, but the printed order lists four. The fourth is still at the dessert station.

Role A: Cook: report three ready and one pending.

Role B: Expediter: identify the missing dessert and obtain its estimate.

Possible opening: Is ticket ninety complete for collection?

Success checks

- Compare containers with the ticket.
- Name the missing component.
- Avoid declaring the whole order ready.

Add a complication: The courier asks whether seeing three containers means they can leave.

LESSON 05 / FACILITATOR NOTES

Communicating a shortage and an alternative

Explain a shortage and obtain the missing choice.

CASE

Three portions of potatoes remain unallocated, but a new ticket requests five. Rice is available as a proposed alternative side; the server must check whether two diners accept it. The cook cannot silently substitute. Agree who obtains the diners' decision.

Teach this move

An available substitute is not an accepted substitute. Use 'if' to connect the offer to the diner's decision.

Vocabulary to check: eighty-six, par level, portion count, substitute item.

Model response

We have three unallocated potato portions for this five-meal ticket. Rice is available as an alternative for two meals, but the guests haven't agreed to that change. Could you ask which two diners, if any, would accept rice? I'll keep the original request clear until you bring back their choices.

Listen for, then coach

Ask learners to point to the case fact behind each important statement. Accept different wording when it preserves meaning, fits the listener, and does not invent an outcome. The choice stays with the diner instead of being silently imposed.

Second-round challenge

Only one diner accepts rice. Restate the remaining shortage and ask the lead about another option.

Language-check answers

1. C - an available alternative Correct. Rice can be offered but isn't yet chosen.
2. D - agree Correct. The plural subject takes 'agree' in this condition.

05 • Conversations

1. Three portions for five orders - The potato shortage in the case.

2. A stock word needs a scope - A cook clarifies whether a shortage concerns one dish or an ingredient.

3. A par level is not an order - A prep cook questions a replenishment request.

Use the complete ten-turn scripts in the learner workbook and conversation lab. Read with roles, identify the decision or open question, then replay without reading.

06 · Say it: second scenario | Only the garnish is unavailable

The herb garnish for a soup is unavailable. The soup itself remains available, but any presentation change needs the lead's decision and a server update.

Role A: Cook: identify the missing component, not the entire dish.

Role B: Lead: confirm whether a no-garnish presentation can be offered; no decision exists at the opening.

Possible opening: Are we marking the whole soup unavailable or just reporting the garnish shortage?

Success checks

- Separate component and dish.
- Obtain the lead's decision.
- Correct the server's earlier message accurately.

Add a complication: A colleague has already told one server 'no soup'.

LESSON 06 / FACILITATOR NOTES

Checking dietary modifications

Challenge an overbroad conclusion using the stated dietary concern.

CASE

Ticket 17 says 'no cheese.' The server then reports that the diner has a milk allergy. The sauce specification has not been checked. The cook must not treat omission of cheese as confirmation that the dish is suitable; the lead can review it with the server.

Teach this move

A change to one ingredient doesn't establish the entire dish's suitability. Keep reported facts and the pending review explicit.

Vocabulary to check: recipe specification, allergen declaration, cross-contact concern, dietary modification.

Model response

Removing the cheese answers the original modifier, but it doesn't establish that the dish meets this guest's milk-allergy concern. We haven't checked the current sauce specification or the handling question. Please keep ticket seventeen pending while the kitchen lead reviews those details and the server explains what remains unconfirmed to the diner.

Listen for, then coach

Ask learners to point to the case fact behind each important statement. Accept different wording when it preserves meaning, fits the listener, and does not invent an outcome. The revised statement identifies the unresolved component.

Second-round challenge

The guest says another restaurant makes it without cheese. Explain why that doesn't verify this recipe.

Language-check answers

1. C - still unverified Correct. The relevant sauce information remains unchecked.
2. D - for Correct. 'Wait for' introduces the thing being awaited.

05 • Conversations

1. A modifier is not an allergy clearance - Ticket 17 from the case.
2. A recipe version matters - A cook finds two ingredient sheets for the same sauce.

3. A vegetarian label needs confirmation - A cook questions a proposed menu description without offering dietary certification.

Use the complete ten-turn scripts in the learner workbook and conversation lab. Read with roles, identify the decision or open question, then replay without reading.

06 · Say it: second scenario | A product changes midweek

A sauce now uses a new branded ingredient. A previous allergen declaration is available, but the new product's declaration has not been checked.

Role A: Cook: question use of the old declaration.

Role B: Lead: obtain the current product information before answering the server.

Possible opening: Does the older declaration cover this new product?

Success checks

- Identify the product change.
- Avoid assuming equivalence.
- Keep the specific dietary question unresolved pending review.

Add a complication: The products have similar packaging and the same descriptive name.

LESSON 07 / FACILITATOR NOTES

Reporting equipment and dish-station needs

Request a named response to an observed equipment problem.

CASE

The display on scale B at the pastry prep bench keeps going blank. No cause is known. The cook has stopped using it and needs the lead to arrange review and confirm whether scale A is available. Do not offer repair instructions.

Teach this move

An observation supports a report, not a technical diagnosis. Name the device, location, effect, and requested help.

Vocabulary to check: equipment fault, out of service, dish rack, bottleneck.

Model response

Scale B at the pastry prep bench keeps losing its display. I've stopped using it, and I don't know the cause. Could you arrange a review and confirm whether scale A is available for this assignment? The pastry prep quantity remains unverified, so I need a confirmed alternative before reporting that task complete.

Listen for, then coach

Ask learners to point to the case fact behind each important statement. Accept different wording when it preserves meaning, fits the listener, and does not invent an outcome. The observation is supportable and avoids guessing at a repair.

Second-round challenge

The colleague asks whether the fault will be fixed before service. Keep the completion time unconfirmed.

Language-check answers

1. B - went blank Correct. This describes the visible change without diagnosing its cause.
2. D - a review Correct. The noun phrase fits before 'of scale B'.

05 • Conversations

1. A blank display is the observation - The scale problem from the case.
2. A specific request for the dish team - A cook requests needed plates during a busy service.

3. A noisy machine needs a location - A kitchen assistant clarifies an equipment report.

Use the complete ten-turn scripts in the learner workbook and conversation lab. Read with roles, identify the decision or open question, then replay without reading.

06 · Say it: second scenario | Two similar equipment labels

A colleague reports 'mixer two' unavailable, but prep uses labels M2 and M12. The supervisor knows M12 is under review; M2's status is unchanged.

Role A: Cook: clarify the exact label.

Role B: Supervisor: identify M12 and the review status.

Possible opening: Do you mean M2 or M12?

Success checks

- Obtain the exact label.
- Repeat the affected location and device.
- Avoid declaring both devices unavailable.

Add a complication: The caller says 'the big one,' but both look similar from your station.

LESSON 08 / FACILITATOR NOTES

Closing and handing over unfinished work

Transfer closing work without making incomplete checks disappear.

CASE

At shift change, the garnish count is complete at twelve portions, the waste-log entry for three damaged tarts awaits the lead's review, and the closing shelf check has not been performed. Ask the incoming cook to accept the shelf check without treating the waste review as complete.

Teach this move

A written entry can await review. A task assigned to someone isn't complete until they perform it and report back.

Vocabulary to check: closing checklist, waste log, carryover, sign-off.

Model response

The garnish count is complete: twelve portions. The entry for three damaged tarts is in the waste log, but the lead hasn't reviewed it yet. The closing shelf check hasn't been done. Can you take that check and confirm when it's complete? I'll follow up with the lead about the separate waste-log review.

Listen for, then coach

Ask learners to point to the case fact behind each important statement. Accept different wording when it preserves meaning, fits the listener, and does not invent an outcome. The revised handover states two different unfinished actions.

Second-round challenge

The lead is unavailable now. Keep review pending rather than treating silence as sign-off.

Language-check answers

1. A - pending Correct. Pending means awaiting action.
2. A - I'll confirm Correct. Future language commits to reporting after the unfinished check.

05 • Conversations

1. Recorded is not reviewed - The shift-change case with garnish, waste entry, and shelf check.
2. A waste reason is unknown - A cook checks a proposed explanation for discarded food.
3. Carryover is not permission - An incoming cook asks what an unfinished stock note establishes.

Use the complete ten-turn scripts in the learner workbook and conversation lab. Read with roles, identify the decision or open question, then replay without reading.

06 · Say it: second scenario | A checklist mark lacks initials

A closing checklist has a tick beside the storage check, but no name or time. Neither cook knows who completed it. The lead can clarify or arrange a new check.

Role A: Outgoing cook: report the ambiguous mark.

Role B: Incoming cook: ask who will verify completion.

Possible opening: Does this tick show a completed check we can actually confirm?

Success checks

- Avoid inferring completion from handwriting.
- Keep status unverified.
- Assign the verification question to the lead.

Add a complication: A colleague says the tick looks like yesterday's handwriting.

Give feedback that helps

Score each criterion 0, 1, or 2. This is a practice rubric, not a professional qualification or CEFR test. Do not award or remove points for a particular accent.

Meaning and accuracy

Keeps the case facts accurate; clearly separates confirmed and unknown information.

Clarity and language

Uses understandable sentences and explains specialist terms when the listener needs it.

Interaction and tone

Responds to the other person's question, checks understanding, and uses an appropriate tone.

Task completion

Makes the requested action or unresolved question clear without inventing authority or facts.

Use the same scale for each criterion

0 - Not yet: The reader or listener cannot yet recover the intended meaning or action.

1 - With support: The message works after a prompt, clarification, or revision.

2 - Independently: The message is clear and accurate without a prompt.

Feedback sequence

First, identify a successful phrase. Next, identify one point where meaning or accuracy needs work. Offer one useful language correction, allow a repeat, and compare the two attempts. A total out of eight describes this performance only; do not translate it into a proficiency level.

Final challenge

Choose a case not rehearsed today. The learner gives a one-minute response, answers two follow-up questions, and switches roles and repeats the exchange. Add the lesson's second-round challenge. Compare the result with an earlier attempt using the four criteria.

Use the language responsibly

All situations, quantities, recipes, times, and product details are fictional English practice, not culinary certification or food-safety instruction. This course does not teach cooking temperatures, chemical use, equipment repair, or allergen-control procedures. Follow workplace training and the responsible kitchen lead's decisions. It concerns kitchen communication rather than hospitality management.

Meaning before performance

Use specialist terms only when they help the listener. Explain unfamiliar words, preserve uncertainty, and ask when an instruction or responsibility is unclear. The model responses illustrate language; they do not authorize professional actions.

Sources and further reading

The cases, workshops, and explanations are original teaching material. These references provide language frameworks and selected professional context. References were checked in September 2026; consult current local guidance for actual work.

Digital.gov: plain-language guidance

<https://digital.gov/guides/plain-language>

Council of Europe: CEFR descriptors

<https://www.coe.int/en/web/common-european-framework-reference-languages/cefr-descriptors>

U.S. Bureau of Labor Statistics, Occupational Outlook Handbook: Cooks

<https://www.bls.gov/ooh/food-preparation-and-serving/cooks.htm>

O*NET OnLine: Cooks, Restaurant

<https://www.onetonline.org/link/summary/35-2014.00>

Your next step

Choose one expression you can use in a genuine work situation. Rehearse it with fictional details, then adapt the wording to your role and audience.